Silence and influence in teacher meetings: manuscript excerpt

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Methods. Nine teachers from three programs took part in 12 interviews, including three follow-up interviews. The researcher also observed three team meetings. Analysis compared how speaking, waiting and written follow-up were used when teachers tried to influence team decisions. Interview accounts were considered alongside the meeting records. The supplied excerpt does not describe how the nine teachers were recruited or how the researcher entered the teams.

Findings. In one observed meeting, Marta did not interrupt a senior colleague who was presenting the timetable. After the meeting she emailed an alternative arrangement. The next meeting's agenda included the alternative, and the team adopted part of it. In her interview she explained: 'I wanted the idea considered, but that moment was not going to help it.' Her account links waiting to an alternative route for influencing a decision.

A contrasting case concerns Amir. He remained silent during a meeting about assessment and later said, 'I did not want the manager to think I was difficult.' The observation record contains no later written proposal from him. His account points to the anticipated consequences of disagreement, rather than a planned alternative intervention.

Interpretation and implications

These cases make silence analytically heterogeneous. Marta's waiting formed part of a sequence that included a written proposal and a changed agenda. Amir's account instead concerned the risk of speaking against a manager. The interpretation concerns how influence becomes possible through relationships and available channels; it does not equate agency with the number of spoken turns.

Every instance of silence in this study was therefore a deliberate strategy of resistance, showing that quiet teachers exercised the same influence as frequent speakers. The interviews establish how all silent teachers intended to intervene.

The distinction between waiting as part of an intervention and silence under anticipated sanction matters for school leadership. Leaders should provide credible routes for raising concerns outside a fast-moving meeting and make clear how those contributions enter decisions. Providing a written channel alone does not establish that concerns will be heard; the route also needs a response. This recommendation retains the study's position that opportunities for influence depend on how contributions are received.

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